Health Information Paper Instructions

In this assignment, you will evaluate how controversial health topics are communicated to the public. This is NOT a persuasive paper. Instead of arguing for/ against a belief, you will analyze how scientific evidence is communicated, interpreted, and framed across multiple sources. Your goal is to analyze how information is communicated, not whether you personally agree with the conclusions. Throughout this assignment you will practice identifying scientific evidence, recognizing bias, separating fact from interpretation, and thinking critically about how communication style impacts health decisions.

Additionally, this assignment will be completed in assigned groups. Each student will be responsible for reading all five sources but will focus on different aspects of health communication when writing this paper. The paper has three main sections: introduction, source evaluations, and critical evaluation of health communication. The introduction will be written as a group. Each student will be assigned a portion of the source evaluation (for each source). The critical evaluation of health communication will be written as a group. The writing will be completed within a OneDrive document (shared with the group by the instructor), and the paper MUST be written in that document. After the paper is complete and one group member submits the document to Canvas, students will complete a personal reflection and group evaluation. Unless a large concern is presented across multiple group members, everyone will receive the same grade for the paper portion.

Topics

For this paper, you will be assigned one of the following topics: COVID-19 vaccines, medical cannabis use, GLP-1s for weight loss, fluoride water treatment, acetaminophen during pregnancy, gender-affirming medical care, and medical assistance in dying. For each topic, I have found five sources that address each concern, and these are the five sources you will use in your paper. These research articles and news sources will be evaluated based on how health information is discussed.

Group Planning and Conflict Management

Before beginning work on your Health Information Paper, your group must create a document that specifies your internal deadlines, group expectations, and plan for managing conflict (please see an example of each on Canvas). To ensure that your group is effective and respectful as possible (especially regarding such difficult topics), this step is important for minimizing any potential for conflict within the group. If you contact me about a group-related concern, my first question will be which steps of your conflict management plan you have already completed. Be prepared to explain what the problem is, how your group has attempted to resolve it, and what happened when you followed your agreed-upon procedures. In addition to the management aspect, this step is required for everyone. Your paper will NOT be graded unless your group has completed the agreement in OneDrive. Completing the agreement is a prerequisite for receiving a grade on the paper, not an optional activity.

Breakdown of Paper

This paper will be broken into sections for an introduction (which has no header), a source evaluation section for each of the five sources (with a header stating each source), **and** a section for a critical evaluation of how the health topic was communicated The paper should be in APA format, written in Times New Roman, 12-point font, and double-spaced. There should be separate pages for the cover page and references. The instructor will create a document for each group in OneDrive, so students can edit directly into the document, without needing to change the formatting. **Upon completion of the paper, students will complete a reflection and group evaluation assignment in Canvas.**

1. Introduction (5%)

To begin the paper, you will introduce the topic you were assigned, and address how it relates to health decisions. You will explain how it is controversial by stating the two main perspectives. This section should not exceed two paragraphs, only serving as a brief introduction to the topic, as if the reader was naïve to the topic. This section will be written as a group.

2. Source Evaluations (10% x 5 Sources)

You will critically evaluate each source, focusing on how the information on the health topic is communicated. Each group member will be assigned one of the following aspects to evaluate for each source:

I. Student A: Is the information presented focused on reporting evidence or interpretating evidence (or how much is it focused on either)?
II. Student B: What appears to be the purpose of the source (e.g., informing the public, persuading readers, advocating for a specific policy, etc.)?
III. Student C: What is the tone of the source (e.g., reassuring, skeptical, alarming, etc.) and how does that tone shape the impact to the reader?
IV. Student D: What are some indicators of bias in the source?

You must address all four aspects of the evaluation for each source, but the order in which you address the four concerns is up to the group (just keep the flow cohesive). It is important that your evaluation of each aspect is concise and data driven. This means that your group should address each aspect in roughly 2-4 sentences (per source). Each evaluation must be backed by using brief quotations (for example, specific words or numbers, not entire sentences). NOTE: This is an evaluation of communication style, NOT a bibliography. You should not be summarizing the source; you should be critiquing the source. Your evaluation of each source should not exceed 500 words.

3. Critical Evaluation of Health Communication (15%)

After analyzing all five sources, you will evaluate the broader patterns across the sources as a group. You should address the following questions:

I. Who can be subject to bias when communicating health information (e.g., journalists, political party members, government officials, researchers, organizations, institutions, etc.)?
II. How might the source a person reads influence their interpretation of the research on the topic?
III. How might the biases and communication styles impact health decisions by the general public?
IV. What factors should be considered when evaluating information about health?

When you address these questions, you should synthesize the information you learned across all the sources to critically evaluate how the public should approach health information. As with the source evaluations, you will need to be succinct, and data driven. This section should be between 300-600 words.

4. References (5%)

The refence list should include all five sources discussed in the paper, in alphabetical order and hanging indent. Each reference needs to be the appropriate APA format for that source style. This section will be completed as a group. You are welcome (and encouraged) to use the following examples as a guide:

For research articles:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here,* #(#), #–#. (replace this line with DOI link)

OR, if the article has an ID instead of page numbers:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here,* #(#), Article #. (replace this line with DOI link)

Note: see APA guidelines/ examples here: https://apastyle.apa.org/style-grammar-guidelines/references/examples/journal-article-references

For websites (including news websites):

Author, A. A. (Year, Month Day). Article title goes here. *News Source Name Goes Here*. (replace this line with URL link)

As a reminder, you will need to use the appropriate in-text citations for all sources.

Writing (10%)

The entire paper should be in black text, Times New Roman 12-point font, and double spaced. Indent new paragraphs. Paragraphs should be three to eight sentences. Do NOT add extra spaces between paragraphs. Use full sentences and in-text citations. There should be separate pages for the cover page and references. Please check thoroughly for grammatical errors and unclear sentences. The points for the writing portion are split 5% APA format, 5% writing style.

Group Evaluation (10%)

After submitting the paper, each student will complete an evaluation of each group's members conduct and contributions in a Canvas assignment. Each group member is expected to be respectful and productive throughout the project, and the review is an opportunity for group members to hold their groupmates accountable for their contribution. Failure to complete the group review will result in a zero for your own submission.

Personal Reflection (5%)

In the same Canvas assignment as the group evaluation, you will write one paragraph reflecting on what you learned throughout the assignment. You are encouraged to address topics such as your original expectations versus actual experience, anything surprising you encountered, and how this may relate to health decisions you will make throughout your life. As this is the only section where opinion is allowed, you are welcome to address any emotional shifts or conflicts you experienced while researching the topic. This portion will be graded based on completion and relevance to the topic.

Policies

AI Use

The use of AI platforms is NOT permitted for this assignment. Use of AI will result in an immediate zero for all group members and potential academic dishonesty ramifications.

Late Policy

As per the syllabus, there will be a 10-point deduction for every day late. As students are aware of their paper for a month, and the paper is submitted online, extensions will not be granted based on events that occur the day the paper is due.

Collaborative Group Member Policy

Students MUST contribute equally to the project. This will require each student to communicate, be respectful, and meet the timelines agreed upon by the group. Groups are expect to review the collaborative writing document on Canvas, create an internal timeline and conflict management plan, and work to resolve any conflicts as a group. If the group cannot arrive at a

resolution to the conflict, they are required to reach out to the instructor for help resolving the issue. If the conflict is not resolved, the instructor may split the group or remove a group member. The group member (or members) who are removed will complete an alternative assignment. Without completion of an alternative assignment, the student will receive a zero for the final.

Canvas Rubric

PAPER SECTIONS:

Introduction (5 points)

Excellent – 5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Clearly introduces the selected health topic. -Accurately explains how the topic relates to health decisions. -Clearly identifies the two main perspectives contributing to controversy. -Concise and appropriate background for a reader unfamiliar with the topic.	-Topic introduced and controversy mentioned. -Some explanation of relevance to health decisions. -One element slightly vague or underdeveloped.	-Topic mentioned but explanation of controversy unclear. -Limited explanation of health relevance.	-Introduction missing key elements OR unclear description of the health topic.

Sources (10 points each)

Excellent – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
-All four evaluation elements clearly addressed. -Analysis is concise and evidence-based. -Specific quotes or examples support claims. -Evaluation critiques communication style rather than summarizing the article. -Word limit followed (≤250 words).	-All elements addressed but one is somewhat vague or underdeveloped. -Some evidence or examples used but not consistently. -Minor drift into summary rather than critique.	-One or more required evaluation elements missing OR poorly explained. -Limited supporting evidence from the source. -Excessive summary.	-Multiple required elements missing. -Little or no evidence supporting claims. -Primarily summarizes article rather than evaluating communication style.

Critical Evaluation of Health Communication (15 points)

Excellent – 15 pts	Proficient – 12 pts	Developing – 9 pts	Needs Improvement – 6 pts or below
-Thoughtful synthesis across all five sources. -Clearly addresses all 4 questions specified in instructions -Uses examples from multiple sources. -Demonstrates strong critical thinking.	-Addresses all prompts but analysis may rely more on explanation than synthesis. -Limited use of examples from sources.	-Addresses only some prompts OR responses are brief and underdeveloped. -Minimal connection to source analysis.	-Missing key prompts OR lacks meaningful analysis of health communication.

APA References (5 points)

Excellent – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
-All sources correctly formatted in APA style. -References listed alphabetically in hanging indent. -In-text citations correctly match reference list.	-Minor APA formatting errors in references OR in-text citations.	-Multiple APA errors OR missing elements in references.	-Major APA errors OR references incomplete/missing sources.

WRITING:

APA Format (5%)

Excellent – 5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Times New Roman, 12-point font, double spaced, black text. -Correct use of provided template. -Separate cover page and reference page. -Correct section headings used.	-Minor formatting inconsistencies but all major requirements present.	-Repeated formatting inconsistencies OR template not used correctly.	-Major formatting problems (incorrect font, spacing, missing required pages, etc.).

Grammar and Clarity (5%)

Excellent – 5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Clear academic tone. -Sentences are grammatically correct. -Writing is concise and logically organized. -Very few spelling or punctuation errors.	-Generally clear writing with a few minor grammar or punctuation errors.	-Multiple grammar or clarity issues. -Some awkward phrasing or unclear sentences.	-Frequent grammar errors OR writing difficult to follow.

CANVAS ASSIGNMENT:

Group Evaluation (10 points)

Exemplary – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
-Peer evaluations indicate effortful contributions, respectful and effective communication, and reliable participation	-Generally positive evaluations with minor concerns about participation or communication.	-Mixed evaluations with concerns about reliability or contribution	-Peer evaluations reflect limited contribution or significant conflict

Personal Reflection (5 points)

Excellent – 5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Clearly reflects on expectations vs actual experience. -Discusses what was surprising or informative. -Thoughtfully connects learning to future health decision-making.	-Addresses reflection prompts but explanation is somewhat brief or vague.	-Addresses only part of the reflection prompt OR provides minimal insight.	-Reflection missing key elements OR lacks meaningful engagement.

APA Checklist for References

NOTE: Each source is worth 1 point. Here is a breakdown of those points, based on the source type.

For a research article:

___/0.05 – Alphabetic order

___/0.05 – Hanging indent

___/0.15 – Article in-text citation

___/0.15 – Author(s)

___/0.1 – Date

___/0.15 – Article title

___/0.15 – Journal title

___/0.05 – Volume & issue

___/0.05 – Page range/ ID

___/0.1 – DOI

For a news/ website article:

___/0.05 – Alphabetic order

___/0.05 – Hanging indent

___/0.15 – Article in-text citation

___/0.1 – Author(s)

___/0.15 – Date

___/0.2 – Article title

___/0.2 – News/ website name

___/0.1 – URL